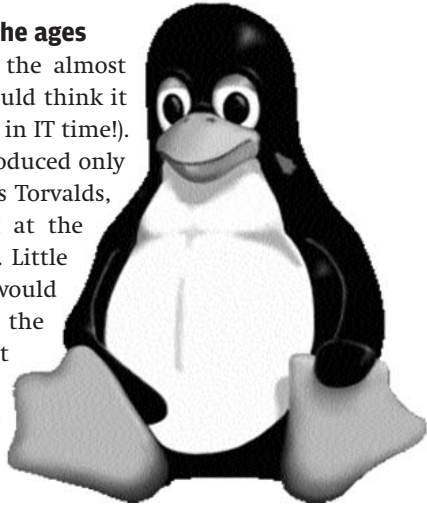


1.1 A Brief History Of Linux

The penguin's growth through the ages

Considering the geek value and the almost cult status of Linux today, you would think it has been around for eons (at least in IT time!). Actually, Linux was officially introduced only in 1991 by its famed creator Linus Torvalds, who at the time was a student at the University of Helsinki in Finland. Little did he know that his creation would grow in size and popularity to the extent it has today. That he did not expect too much to come forth from his work is evident from this much-too-famous excerpt of his mail to a newsgroup:



“Hello everybody out there using minix - I'm doing a (free) operating system (just a hobby, won't be big and professional like gnu) for 386(486) AT clones. This has been brewing since April, and is starting to get ready. I'd like any feedback on things people like/dislike in minix, as my OS resembles it somewhat(same physical layout of the file-system (due to practical reasons) among other things).”

He ended his mail saying:

“PS. Yes — it's free of any minix code, and it has a multi-threaded fs. It is NOT portable (uses 386 task switching etc), and it probably never will support anything other than AT-harddisks, as that's all I have :-).”

Let's look at some of the interesting things that happened before and after that mail. The story of operating systems—especially that of open source OSes—is inspiring to anyone who loves technology. Linux will only be wholly appreciated when the “behind the scenes” of its development is known.